HEROES OF NORMANDIE

The Devil Pig News

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THE VERCORS MAQUIS

BE ENTICED BY THE MOUNTAINS!!!

The Vercors mountain range, situated Southwest of Grenoble, had been a sought-after destination long before the German offensive of July 1944. Already at the end of 1939, refugees appeared in the area. Amongst them, several well-off foreign families on the run from Nazism but also lots of youngsters, Parisien or Southern French kids straight out of their primary or secondary school. This situation lasted until the start of 1942 when several groups of guerilla fighters joined up with the Lyon resistance organisation. Their first actions consisted primarily of receiving STO (forced labor) dodgers and offering them hospitality. Nothing beats fresh mountain air to heal and strengthen people.

"Mountainmen must keep scaling the mountains."

This coded message sent by the BBC on the 25th of February 1943 caused the movement to pick up the pace as they carried on with what they had been doing since 1942: create makeshift landing strips and stock up on weapons and ammunition. Moreover, by denying all access to unwelcome outsiders, they turned the Vercors plateau into a sanctuary. Around this time, as these resistants were then considered part of the Secret Army, they could benefit from funds allocated by Jean Moulin. As this allowed the organization to grow stronger, their ranks counted about 400 partisans ready and able to fight by the end of 1943. From November '43 parachute drops provided them with the material to mount guerilla and sabotage actions against the Germans who had replaced the Italian occupation forces in September.



In the beginning of 1944, German forces aided by Vichy Régime militants launched a series of missions against the Vercors. The resistants did all they could to avoid being drawn into a full scale battle as that would do them more bad than good. The inhabitants of the region who might support the Resistance paid a heavy toll as they were repressed, abused and deported. On the first of June 1944, London sent the, perhaps oddly humoristic, encoded message "There is water in the gas". This was to warn the French about the imminent Operation Overlord and to keep them on their toes because they needed to distract and annoy the Germans then more than ever. The command of the Vercors (united FFI since February 1944) is entrusted to Lieutenant colonel Huet and his chief of staff Captain Pierre Tannant. At that time, the Vercors could muster about 4000 men supported by reinforcements from adjoining regions.

"The Alpine mountain goat jumps"... does it?

To no avail rather... Since "Overlord" was well underway in Normandie and more landings were being projected in the South of France, any potential offensive actions carried out by the Vercors Resistance were no longer a priority at all for the Allies. Lack of proper communication between London and Vercors on this matter seriously affected the planned operation "Montagnards" (Mountainmen) which even triggered a conflict of influence between several covert offices of Free France. Anyway, halfway through 1944, since the area had been proclaimed as "République Libre du Vercors" (Free Republic of Vercors), the people on the plateau considered it a liberated area and acted accordingly. Although massive amounts of arms and material were still being airdropped, alas, the promised airborne reinforcements did not appear. The fact that the resistants thus remained an isolated armed band was to the Germans' advantage as they launched their final offensive to deal with these staunch belligerents once and for all.

The 157th Reserve Division was to be renamed 157th Mountain Division in September 1944. They had been busy fighting resistance and sabotage groups since April of the same year, successfully securing the Glières plateau in the process. In early July it fell on them to conduct Operation Bettina, the attack on the Vercors, for which 8000 men were mobilized. This force included Paratroops, Security units, SS Feldgendarme and Police battalions. As a bitter matter of fact these Germans were assisted by about 500... French militants. The enterprise was to be similar to the efforts made against Tito's partisans in Yugoslavia. On July 13 and 14, the Luftwaffe unleashed hell by pounding the plateau with a massive bombardment. The ground assault commenced on the 21st of July, followed by a glider attack on the 23rd. The stalwart French were unable to oppose the onslaught for long because they were lacking heavy equipment even though the Allies had maintained the logistical parachute drops. As atrocities and warcrimes were plentiful, it didn't take long before the defenders' fate was sealed ... When at long last, in August 1944, airborne troops finally parachuted in during Operation Dragoon, their help came too late for the Vercors.

There's still quite a lot of controversy surrounding the Vercors maquis' destiny. Some tardy decisions of the Free French command and the Allies' role are quite obscure. They can provoke discussions in which words like crime and cowardice might not be shunned at all. In spite of its strategic significance being open for debate as well, there is no denying the Vercors is worthy of a venerable place in the history of French national Resistance during the second World War.

Laurent

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Pierre Tanant

Medals of Honor:
Croix de Guerre 1939-1945 (Cross of War),
Médaille militaire (Military medal),
Médaille de la résistance (Resistance medal).

When plowing through the after-action reports of operations or mission orders from the French army pertaining to episodes which happened in the first half of the 20th century or even a bit later, one can experience the joy of stumbling upon some delightfully outdated expressions. You may come across "sans esprit de recul" (without any spirit of retreat), "avec un bel allant" (with a beautiful going = energy, pace), or the little gem "Boches pris au poste" (Krauts offed at their post) found in a citation written by general Leclerc for one of my relatives in days long before there was any talk of political correctness. Words sometimes take on extra or different meanings and have a variable degree of impact related to the time and context in which they are used.

Pierre Tanant, chief of staff and captain at the time of the Vercors battles, descended from one of those families where "for the homeland" literally meant "gained by the blood that was spilled for it, yours, your father's, his father's and of any other fathers in your ancestry." Back then the expression still carried some seriously solemn gravity, unlike in later days where it might be treated as negligible in some postmodern talk-show...

Pierre Tanant was born in 1909 in Lorraine. His father was a general, ingrained with the sense of importance given to words like honor, homeland and duty. After Saint Cyr military academy, Tanant is assigned to the 153rd regiment of Tirailleurs algériens based in Morocco. In 1938 he has the rank of captain in the 13th Bataillon de Chasseurs Alpins (BCA). He takes part in the campaign in Norway and battles at the Somme in 1940 before being transferred to the armistice army as part of the 6th BCA.

In November '42, as the French free zone was invaded by the Germans, Tanant aided in concealing arms and material. He also took a very active part in setting up a core of fighting units in the Vercors maquis as the chief of staff under lieutenant colonel Huet's orders. During the second semester of 1944 these very combatants were fighting the assaulting enemy on the Vercors plateau. It is a most remarkable feat in the history of the French Resistance.



After World War II, Tanant was part of the occupation forces in Austria. Next he was off to serve in the Algerian War. With the rank of colonel he left the army because of a personal conflict between political obedience and a sense of duty towards the local people. He formulated things as such: "The word that, way too often, is but a word for the politician, assumes the form of a terrible fact for the soldier: words spoken lightly and falsely by one will be written in the dust with the blood of another."

For a long time Pierre Tanant was committed to the remembrance of the fallen before he passed away in Grenoble in 1988.

Laurent

The STO

The Service du travail obligatoire
(English: Compulsory Work Service; STO)
"Because we are convinced
that working is healthy!"

As the exploits on the Eastern Front devoured such enormous masses of soldiers, 300 000 German workers were automatically incorporated into the German army by order of Hitler in 1942. Because this caused a serious labor shortage in Germany, Obergruppenführer Fritz Sauckel was given the task of solving this problem one way or another. The Reich was already commandeering innumerable tons of raw materials from the occupied territories. At that time it also demanded the service of hundreds of thousands, even millions of people, from all over Europe, who were needed to keep the Nazi war machine turning. For France alone, for the duration of the war and excluding the POW's who were toiling already, more than 600 000 people were deported for work. Every single one at the behest of the Vichy government as it could not turn down any requests made by its "beloved" Führer.

Those who were requisitioned for STO had a simple choice: either go to work or alternatively hole up, perhaps even resist by joining the maquis like that of the Vercors for example. Surely, close to two million French citizens of different walks of life were still in Germany at the end of the war.

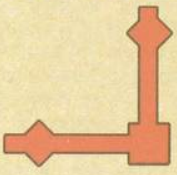
** The fact that some folks willingly went to Germany has since long been a delicate subject. The Vichy regime had negociated that one POW would be set free in exchange for every three workers who turned up. With this in mind, try to understand that some people took up work for the foe only to obtain the release of a close friend or relative. Then again, others may have had sympathies for the German cause. Thus it became difficult to discern sacrifice from collaboration. That could become a matter of life and death at the end of war when those suspected of collaboration were hunted down and punished. Some things were definitely hard to explain when liberation came...*

Laurent



TOPOGRAPHY
THE MOUNTAIN...

CONTOUR LINE



A *contour line* is one that separates two areas that are different elevations.
Shots that cross a red line have their range limited to one square beyond the line, unless the shooter or the target is adjacent to the *contour line*.

Effects on *terrain elements* that reduce *line of sight* apply their effects normally.
Infantry units block *line of sight* if both the shooter and the target are infantry units.
Depending on the type of terrain (hill, bridge, beach, etc.), the *contour line* may affect the movement of crossing units.

ELEVATED POSITION



A unit in an *elevated position* can fire at units outside the element as long as its *LoS* does not cross any square of the elevated position or any walls of the *elevated position*.
A unit in an *elevated position* is less hindered by *obstacles* that block or reduce *line of sight*. So when the *LoS* of a unit in an *elevated position* crosses a *terrain element* or a vehicle, the only affected squares are those directly adjacent to the vehicle or terrain.
If the *line of sight* crosses several obstacle squares, count all the modifiers.
But if the target is not directly adjacent to a vehicle, terrain element, or an *obstacle*, then no obstacle penalties are applied and *LoS* is not blocked.
Infantry units never block the *LoS* of a unit in an *elevated position*.
It is always possible to fire on an *elevated position* from another *elevated position*, unless a third one blocks the *line of sight* between them.
A unit that can be targeted by a unit in an *elevated position* can in return target the elevated position or the unit within.
Elevated positions block the *LoS* of units in other *elevated positions*.